Climate chaos, in fact, is turning into an ever-present nightmare in India. Extreme weather events such as excess rainfall, unseasonal cyclones, debilitating droughts and heat waves have increased in both regularity and intensity across the land. "Every season today is characterised by an extreme weather event," remarks K.J. Ramesh, former director general of the India Meteorological Department (IMD). This is evident in the numbers. From January to March this year, extreme weather battered India on 87 out of 90 days. The pattern was no accident: in 2024, the country suffered climate shocks on 322 out of 366 days, or 88 per cent of the year, according to the Centre for Science and Environment, which maintains a yearly tracker. This surpassed the 318 days in 2023 and 314 in 2022.

AN ENDLESS CALAMITY

Not just lives, but fields, crops, infrastructure and entire livelihoods are being lost to what has become a new normal of ceaseless disasters. A recent report by the UN Office for Disaster Risk Reductions found that even in relatively calmer times—the 20 years from 1998 to 2017—climate-related disasters cost India $79.5 billion (nearly Rs 7 lakh crore). The Reserve Bank of India's Report on Currency and Finance for 2023-24, estimates that, by 2030, extreme heat and humidity could cost India up to 4.5 per cent of its GDP due to lost labour hours. The human toll is as brutal: 3,080 climate-related deaths in 2024–25, the highest in a decade, compared to 2,616 the previous year.

India is now among the top 10 climate-vulnerable nations. The IMD confirms that the country's average temperature has already risen in the past two decades from 25.05°C in 2001 to 25.74°C in 2024. The 0.69°C rise may sound modest but, in climate science, even half a degree can mean the difference between survivable stress and catastrophe. A June 2025 report titled 'Weathering the Storm' by development consultancy IPE Global and advanced mapping solutions provider Esri India estimated that Indian cities will see a twofold rise in heat-wave days and a 43 per cent rise in rainfall intensity by 2030.

Abinash Mohanty, global sector head, climate & sustainability, IPE Global, outlines how climate change is causing several seasonal disruptions. The amount of rain for an entire monsoon is now falling over a day or two, the leading cause behind floods in Kerala, Chennai, Mumbai and Bengaluru in recent years. In fact, he adds, 85 per cent of India's 738 districts are hotspots for extreme events, with 45 per cent of these exhibiting what in climate parlance is called a 'swapping trend'. This means traditionally flood-prone areas face more frequent and intense droughts, and vice versa. So while Rajasthan experienced flash floods in August 2025, drought is threatening the lush green states of the Northeast. Meanwhile, along India's 11,098 km coastline, cyclones are intensifying, and rising seas pose a threat to cities like Mumbai, Chennai and Kolkata.



A flooded locality in Delhi, Sept. 3

Globally, too, red lines have been crossed. The World Meteorological Organization declared 2024 the first year when average global temperatures breached the 1.5°C threshold above pre-industrial levels, the ceiling set by the Paris Climate Accord. It was also the warmest year in 175 years of record-keeping, marked by the unprecedented failure of the Gulf of Panama upwelling—a reliable pulse of cool water into the Pacific Ocean—which did not occur this year for the first time since records began. Each of the past 10 years has been among the hottest on record. In India, the 10 warmest years in 120 years have all been in the past 15 years. The planet is heating at breakneck speed, and India is among those bearing the brunt. "There is a pressing need to consider the consequences of a 2°C target," warns Mohanty. "At our current pace, we will not be able to adapt fast enough."

But why are climate patterns veering so dramatically off their set paths? Earth's climate has always been prone to change, warming and cooling over thousands of years due to shifts in the planet's orbit and tilt. But human activity has accelerated this natural rhythm. Carbon emissions from burning coal, oil and gas, combined with deforestation and urban sprawl, have supercharged the greenhouse effect. This has compacted climate change cycles